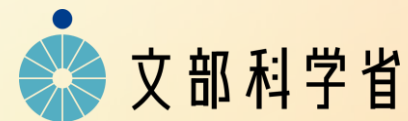


AI for Science Research Innovation Program

Supporting Pioneering Research through
AI for 1,000 Discovery challenges (SPReAD)

User Guide for the Formality Check Tool

June 2, 2026



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- Positioning of the Tool
- Types of Deficiencies Checked by the Tool
- How to Execute the Python Script
- Recommended Operating Environment
- Notes and Disclaimer Regarding Use

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Positioning of the Tool

This tool is provided as reference information to support the review of application documents by principal investigators and their affiliated institutions.

The tool is designed primarily to check for formal deficiencies frequently observed during the first call for proposals, such as missing required fields and unchecked mandatory checkboxes, in research proposal documents and other application materials.

Please note that this tool is intended solely as a supplementary checking tool, and users should be aware of the following:

- Use of this tool is **entirely optional**.
- This tool does not **guarantee the acceptance of application documents, review results, or selection for funding**.
- The items that can be checked by this tool are limited mainly to formal deficiencies frequently identified during the first call for proposals and **do not cover all possible deficiencies**.
- A “no issue detected” result from this tool **does not guarantee the absence of formal deficiencies or other issues in the application documents**.
- **Applicants are ultimately responsible for reviewing the contents of their application documents before submission through their affiliated institutions.**

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Formal Deficiencies Detectable by This Tool

This tool is designed to check primarily for the following types of formal deficiencies. Since the tool does not comprehensively cover all possible deficiencies, applicants are ultimately responsible for reviewing the contents of their application documents before submission through their affiliated institutions.

Target	Examples of Formal Deficiencies Specified in the Application Guidelines (Partial)	Examples of Items Checkable by This Tool
Form 1: Research Proposal Document	Failure to submit required documents Required fields are not completed in the required documents Failure to meet required character counts in the required documents The content of the research proposal document is significantly insufficient, such that information necessary for review cannot be confirmed, or the research intent and plan lack sufficient specificity	- Whether all pages of the research proposal document are blank - Whether all required fields on Page 1 of the research proposal document are completed - Whether all required fields on Page 2 of the research proposal document are completed - Whether the required character count is met on Page 2 of the research proposal document - Whether there are calculation errors in the research budget section on Page 3 of the research proposal document- Whether funding amounts under JPY 100,000 or exceeding JPY 5,000,000 are included on Pages 1 or 3
Forms Other Than Form 1	Required fields are not completed in the required documents	Whether all confirmation and consent checkboxes have been completed- Whether a signature field has been completed- For example, whether comments regarding the appropriateness of the student's research plan and research execution capability are included in Item (5) of Form 4: Consent Confirmation Form by Academic Advisor, etc.
Common to All Forms	Submission not made in the specified manner	Whether required information is included in the file name (form name, e-Rad affiliated institution code, applicant name in Roman letters, etc.)- Whether files are arranged in the specified order



Items / Cases That Cannot Be Checked by This Tool

The following items are outside the scope of this tool.

Target	Detail
Form 1: Research Proposal Document	Matters related to the appropriateness of the research content itself, including logical consistency and validity of the research proposal
	Matters requiring interpretation of the application guidelines, such as eligibility requirements or whether proposed expenses qualify as eligible costs
	Matters requiring professional judgment, including research ethics, security export control, and legal/regulatory compliance
	Other matters not explicitly described in the previous section

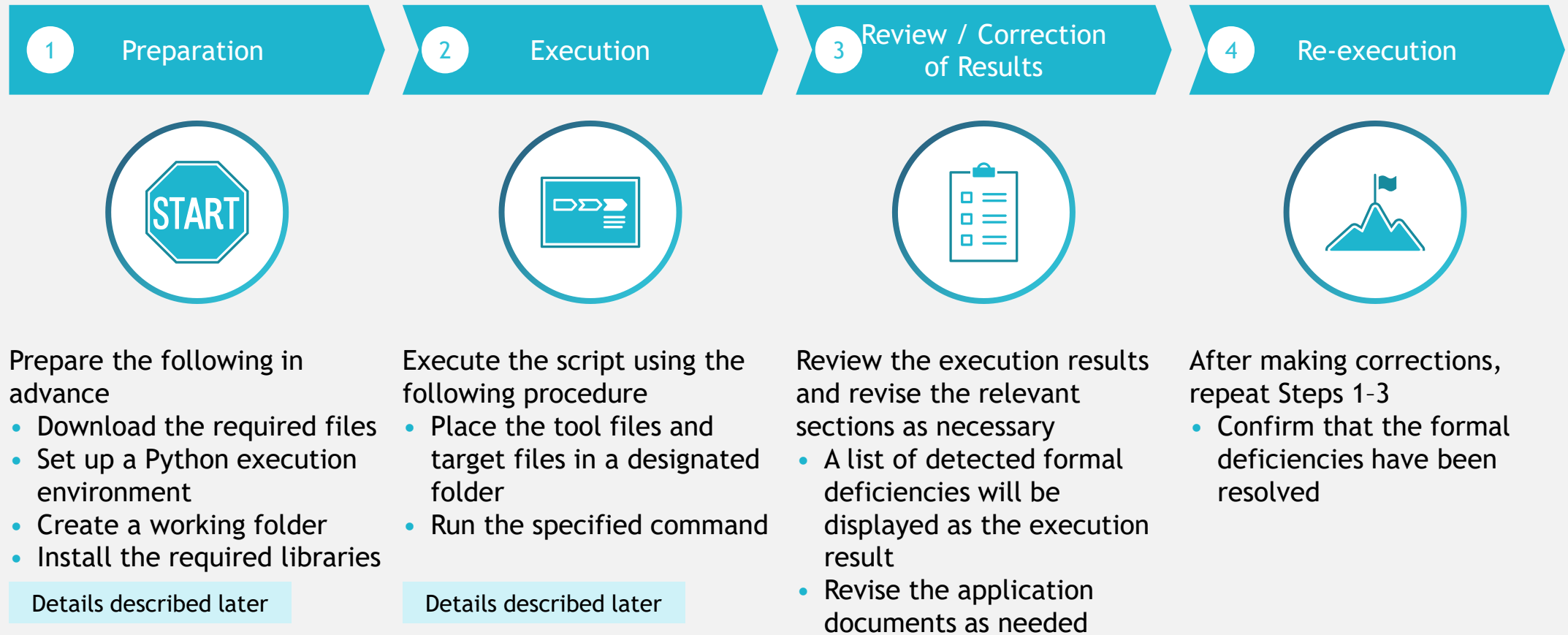
In the following cases, accurate checking cannot be performed by this tool.

Target	Example Cases
Form 1: Research Proposal Document	Cases where the positions of description fields or input cells have been arbitrarily changed
	Cases where tab names have been arbitrarily changed
	Cases where the contents of an Excel file cannot be read
Forms Other Than Form 1	Cases where checkboxes are checked or signatures are filled in by hand (OCR reading functionality is not included)
	Cases where the positions of signatures or checkboxes have been arbitrarily changed

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How to Execute the Python Script



Even if the execution result indicates “No Issues Detected,” this does not guarantee that the application documents are free from all deficiencies.

1 Preparation Process

Download Required Files

From the publicly available Box folder designated by MEXT, please download the files and folders listed below.

- Python scripts (required to perform checks on the Research Plan Application Form and other documents)
 - research_plan_self_check.py
 - form_self_check.py
- README
- User Guide

Note:

Please ensure that all files are obtained from the official distribution source.

While the scripts themselves should be obtained from the official source, users are free to modify or replace them with their own customized versions as needed.

Prepare the Python Execution Environment

To use this tool, please ensure that a Python execution environment is available.

- Install Python 3.11 or later.
- Confirm that Python can be executed on your system.

Note:

Depending on your institution's device restrictions, Python execution may not be permitted. Individual support for Python environment setup is not provided.

Create a Working Folder

Create a working folder in any location on your local computer.

Install Required Libraries

1. Launch the Command Line Interface (CLI)

Please open one of the following:

- Windows
 - PowerShell / Command Prompt
- macOS
 - Terminal

2. Navigate to the Working Folder
Example:

```
cd check_tool
```

3. Install the Required Libraries
Example:

```
pip install openpyxl
pdfminer.six pypdf
```

2 3 Execution Process & Review / Correction of Results Process

Place the Tool and Target Files in a Working Folder

In the working folder you created, place the following files:

- Application documents to be checked by the Python scripts

Note:

research_plan_self_check.py is intended for the Research Plan Application Form, while form_self_check.py is intended for the other application forms.

To prevent the results from being mixed, please prepare separate folders and run each script independently.

Run the Scripts

Please execute the following scripts as appropriate:

- `python research_plan_self_check.py` (for the Research Plan Application Form)
- `python form_self_check.py` (for the other application forms)

Note:

This can also be run using Command Prompt or Jupyter Notebook.

By default, the tool checks the files located in the folder from which the script is executed, and outputs the results to the same folder. If you would like to check files in a different folder or output the results to another location, please modify the settings at the beginning of each script (`INPUT_PATH`, `OUTPUT_FILE`, and `RECURSIVE`) accordingly.

Review the Results

After execution, a list of detected formal deficiencies will be displayed.

Please review the output result files (Microsoft Excel: Judgment Summary / Detail Check) and make **revisions** as necessary.

- Judgment Summary
 - Provides an overall determination as to whether the target file may contain any deficiencies.
- Detailed Check
 - Identifies specific sections of the target file where deficiencies may have occurred.

Note:

The result files will be output to the working folder.

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Recommended Environment

This tool is recommended for use in the following environment.

- OS: Windows / macOS (latest versions recommended)
- Python: Specified version or later
- Required libraries: Please refer to the README

Please also note the following:

- The tool may not function correctly due to differences in OS, Python version, libraries, or other factors.
- Python execution may be restricted by your organization's security policies or device restrictions.
- This tool is for optional use, and we are generally unable to provide support for execution errors caused by individual environment configurations.

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Notes and Disclaimer Regarding Use

【Notes】

1. Usage Environment
 - This tool is intended to be executed within the researcher's local environment.
 - This tool is designed not to perform any external network communication.
 - To protect original files, backing up research proposal documents and related files before use is recommended.
2. Official Version
 - Please obtain the official version of the tool from the public Box(<https://mext.box.com/s/n7vxl45kvck26g5oh04ebzuaxlltoc2>) designated by the MEXT.
 - Please note that you are free to modify the official tool/script for your own use within the scope of personal utilization.
However, we kindly ask that modified versions of the script not be redistributed.
3. Libraries Used
 - The libraries used in this tool have been reviewed in advance prior to distribution.
4. Support
 - General guidance on how to use this tool will be provided through this user guide and explanations at public offering briefing sessions.
 - However, individual support for execution errors caused by user-specific environments, Python environment setup, device configuration, etc. will generally not be provided.
5. Other
 - The contents of this tool may be updated as necessary.
 - Please confirm the update history and version information before use.

【Disclaimer】

- MEXT shall not be held responsible for any issues or damages arising from the use of, or inability to use, this tool.
- The contents of this tool may be updated or changed without prior notice as necessary.
- The "Notes" included in this User Guide are subject to change. Any changes will be announced on the official website.